

died in the 1950's; his son allegedly refused to pay the final bill, and Father sued him and won. Cool. Tough. Pretty darned solitary. And the son? He is now dead himself. Father's longest lasting friend? John Her-schfelder, an engineer, who had been close to Father since childhood. But he only saw or spoke to Johnny maybe once every four years as an adult. Father couldn't stand the guy's wife—drove him crazy. Still, when Johnny was in the hospital, dying, Father made regular trips there to sit with him. Johnny was important to Father. Yet in life, he couldn't find ways to be with the man, because Father was solitary. Stoic. Alone, except with my mother. He just didn't like people very much. Most people like to be around friends, just to be with them and bask in their companionship, sort of glowing. He didn't.

He liked to be alone or with my mother; and pretty much of the time when he was with my mother, they were both alone, she in the family den and he in the living room. It was just who he was. But he was beyond anxious if he was separated from her when he wasn't at work or in the garden. Other people? He just didn't like being around other people much. He liked me, but if I was around him too much, it bugged him. Or Arthur, and he liked Arthur better than anyone but my mother. But the reality is that Father was just a solitary guy. Regardless of with whom he interacted, it was all relative degrees of solitude. When Arthur and then I came to work with him in the early 1970's, it drove him nuts, in my opinion. He had been pretty much alone and solitary his whole career, and being around us all that time was too much. Seeing that it drove him nuts, realizing I hadn't yet really learned who he was and, as stated earlier, realizing there wasn't a career opportunity with him because he couldn't delegate, I determined rather promptly to distance myself a bit to make him and me less nuts. I quit his employment and started out on my own within a year. But I remained in the same building. I had an unusual ability to not be bothered much by Father's weirdness and to separate from him but remain fairly close. Arthur couldn't do that. Too much emotion. Arthur isn't as emotionally tough as I am, never was; I don't know why. I always thought both my brothers took Father much too seriously and, ultimately, couldn't take him nearly as much or as well as I could. Ultimately Father's emotion took too big a toll on Arthur, and he left the industry completely in 1977 and moved to Seattle and on to academics. My father was simply not a man to be close to people.